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Hiding in Plain Sight: Taking Control of Hypertension

Learning how to lower your risk of the "silent killer" that is reshaping millions of lives

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Abstract

Nearly $\frac{1}{4}$ Canadian adults suffer from hypertension, but it's often dismissed as "not serious" simply because there's no symptoms until it triggers something worse. This article brings a clear and comprehensive analysis on what hypertension is and how to manage and live with it backed by peer-reviewed articles, meant for all ages. More importantly though, it powers readers with the knowledge that can change fear into action, which can help them in the present or the future and coincides with AiM's mission of empowering health literacy.

Introduction

Imagine feeling completely fine at a routine check-up, then being told your blood pressure puts you at risk for serious disease. This happens to hundreds of millions of people each year, with the number of people diagnosed doubling between 1990 and 2019 (NCD-RisC, 2021). Hypertension, also known as high blood pressure, rarely causes any symptoms at all, which perfectly explains its nickname “the silent killer”.

Hypertension means that the force of blood pushing against your artery walls is consistently too high. Blood pressure is measured by the readings of two numbers: systolic (the pressure when your heart beats) over diastolic (the pressure when your heart rests between beats). For example, a reading of 120/80 means 120 systolic and 80 diastolic, which is often considered the borderline between normal and high blood pressure.

Nearly 1 in 4 Canadian adults live with this condition, and unfortunately, many don't know about it (Canada). When left untreated, it quietly damages the heart, kidneys, and blood vessels over the years, long before any symptoms may appear. By the time they do appear, it is often a sign of a much more serious disease (Zhou et al. 2021). Understanding what hypertension is and how to catch it early is one of the easiest ways to protect your long-term health.

Causes/Risk Factors

Blood pressure rises and falls naturally throughout each day, going up when you exercise or feel stressed, and drops when you rest. Hypertension is diagnosed when these readings stay elevated consistently, not just in short jagged periods of time.

There are two main types of hypertension. Primary hypertension develops gradually over many years and has no single cause since it's linked to a mix of factors including age, genetics, diet, and lifestyle choices. Secondary hypertension is caused by an underlying condition, like kidney disease, for example, and tends to appear more suddenly. Primary is the most common out of the two, affecting around 90-95% of patients (Mircea CİNTEZA, 2014).

Luckily, there are measures that can be taken. Risk factors for hypertension fall into two categories: modifiable and non-modifiable. As the name suggests, modifiable factors are the ones that you can change. For example, diet choices like a high intake

of salt, lack of consistent exercise, consumption of alcohol, smoking/vaping, and constant stress can all cause high blood pressure. By modifying these lifestyle choices, you can reduce your risk of hypertension by a lot. Non-modifiable factors are the risks that you cannot control. These include aging, genetics, and family history (Cheraghi et al., 2025).

Signs and Symptoms

Most serious health conditions come with warning signs, so it's normal to expect the same from hypertension. However, hypertension breaks that rule entirely, being known as the "silent killer" because it usually causes no symptoms at all, even when blood pressure has been high for many years (Cheraghi et al. 2025).

This is exactly what makes hypertension so dangerous. A person can feel completely healthy while on the inside, their blood vessels are slowly weakening day after day. Without any regular check-ups, high blood pressure can go unnoticed until it leads to a bigger problem, such as a heart attack or a stroke. By the time symptoms show up, they're often signs that damage has already occurred within the body.

Although people may report mild symptoms such as headaches or dizziness, virtually no patients feel standard day-to-day symptoms. In fact, studies show that 77% of diagnosed patients convince themselves they can feel it (Granados-Gómez et al., 2015). Sometimes these symptoms are for another condition. This is exactly why routine checks are so important. Since the body doesn't send warning signals, testing is the only reliable way to catch hypertension early on. A check doesn't take a lot of time and can happen at your local pharmacy, a doctor's office, or even at home with the appropriate equipment.

The takeaway from this is simple: you cannot feel your way to knowing your blood pressure. Regular checks and consistent monitoring is the tool that fills up the gap left by the lack of symptoms. Though it might seem tiring, it's definitely a habit worth spending time building.

Diagnosis

Speaking of routine check ups, you may ask how hypertension is exactly diagnosed. Well, it isn't complicated, but it still does need to be done the right way. Essentially, a medical professional will measure your blood pressure with a sphygmomanometer,

which is a cuff-based device that squeezes the arm and tracks pressure as blood flows through it (Cheraghi et al. 2025). The reading will show two numbers: systolic over diastolic pressure.

Now, a single high reading isn't enough for a reliable diagnosis since blood pressure naturally rises and falls throughout the day depending on factors like stress, activity, and even how nervous someone may feel during the check up. That's exactly why professionals take multiple readings on different days before confirming a diagnosis.

The general threshold for hypertension is a reading of 130/80 mmHg or higher (Cheraghi et al. 2025). mmHg is millimeters of mercury, and it's the unit used to measure blood pressure. Readings below that threshold are considered normal or mildly elevated.

As mentioned earlier, there are factors that may impede the results. Therefore, to get an accurate reading, there are some simple conditions that need to be respected, such as sitting still and avoiding caffeine or exercise right before the test since they can all affect the acute blood pressure reading. Skipping these steps can throw off the results.

Because hypertension has no clear symptoms, diagnosis through a proper way is the only dependable way to catch its presence. Though a routine check up may seem simple, it still needs to be done correctly to avoid false information that might hurt instead of help.

Treatment and Management

The good news is that most causes of hypertension are modifiable, meaning they can be changed through everyday choices. That's why doctors call it the most prevalent yet modifiable cardiovascular risk factor (Tokcan et al., 2024).

The most important line of treatment is lifestyle changes. For example, reducing sodium intake, eating more fruits and vegetables, getting consistent exercise, limiting alcohol and smoking (better yet, completely avoiding), and maintaining a healthy body weight all help lower blood pressure. These actions work since they reduce the strain/stress put on the blood vessels and the heart, which addresses the root of the problem rather than just scratching the surface.

However, when lifestyle changes aren't enough on their own, medication comes into the frame. Common choices include diuretics, which help the body release excess sodium and water, as well as ACE inhibitors, which help relax the blood vessels and therefore ease the blood flow. It is important to keep in mind, however, that a doctor should be the one deciding which medication fits best for the person based on their overall health, how their body responds to treatment, and their medical history.

The key takeaway is that hypertension isn't something that happens to a person who is powerless to respond. With lifestyle adjustments and medical treatment, there are many real, proven, and effective tools that lend control back into the patient's hands. It must also be said that managing this condition isn't about completely eliminating it overnight; rather, it's about steadily lowering the chance of harm through choices made every day.

Living with Hypertension

Managing hypertension long-term requires a few consistent habits. Incorporating them into your daily or weekly routine is key to controlling it over time.

Starting off, home monitoring is one of the most useful tools available. All that is required is to check blood pressure regularly at home using a simple at-home cuff. This way, both the doctor and the patient can track the results and identify changes early, which is extremely useful since hypertension itself doesn't have any symptoms.

Next is medication adherence. Make sure to consistently follow your doctor's orders on how to take your medication. Even when you feel fine, never ever skip a dose, since even if it is occasionally, it can let blood pressure climb back to unsafe levels without any warning signs.

After that, there are dietary changes. This is all part of the lifestyle side of treatment discussed earlier. Finally, routine checkups with your doctor. Regular visits allow adjustment to medication, tracking of overall health, and reassurance that your treatment plan is on track. Please keep in mind that treatment plans are highly individualized, and you should always consult your personal physician before starting or modifying treatment.

Conclusion

So, to end off, make sure that you understand that hypertension isn't dangerous because it's an untreatable disease; rather, it's dangerous because of its invisibility of symptoms and the fact that it's underestimated. Once you know how to look out for it, you're once again in control of it.

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All claims in this article are supported by evidence-based sources.

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